

Cochlea

The coiled structure in the inner ear that contains the organ of Corti, which converts sound vibrations into **nerve** impulses for transmission to the brain.

Collagen

The body's most important structural **protein**, present in bones, **tendons**, **ligaments**, and other connective **tissues**.

Colon

The part of the large intestine that extends from the caecum to the rectum. Its main function is to conserve water by absorbing it from the bowel contents.

Cornea

The transparent dome at the front of the eyeball that is the eye's main focusing **lens**.

Coronary

A term meaning "crown". Refers to the arteries that encircle and supply the heart with blood.

Corpus callosum

The wide, fan-shaped band consisting of about 20 million **nerve** fibres that connects the two hemispheres of the **cerebrum**.

Cortex

Outer layer in various **organs**, such as the cerebral cortex (brain), **renal** cortex (**kidney**), and adrenal cortex (hormone-producing gland on top of the kidney).

Cranial nerves

The 12 pairs of **nerves** emerging from the brain and **brainstem**. They include the nerves for smell, sight, eye movement, facial movement and sensation, hearing, taste, and head movement.

Cytoplasm

Watery or jelly-like fluid that fills the bulk of a cell; it contains many **organelles**.

D**Dermis**

The thick inner layer of skin, made of connective **tissue**; contains structures such as sweat glands.

Diaphragm

The dome-shaped muscular sheet that separates the chest from the abdomen. When the muscle contracts, the dome flattens, increasing chest volume and drawing air into the lungs.

Diastole

The period in the heartbeat cycle when all four chambers are relaxed and the heart is filling with blood. See **systole**.

Digestive system

The mouth, **pharynx**, **oesophagus**, stomach, and intestines. Associated **organs** are the **pancreas**, **liver**, and **gallbladder** and their ducts.

DNA (Deoxyribonucleic acid)

A chemical with a double-helix structure that carries genetic information in the form of the order of its paired subunits (**bases**); packaged into **chromosomes**.

Duodenum

The C-shaped first part of the small intestine, into which the stomach empties. Ducts from the **gallbladder**, the **liver**, and the **pancreas** all enter the duodenum.

E**Eardrum**

The membrane separating the outer ear from the **middle ear** that vibrates in response to sound.

Embryo

The developing baby from conception until the eighth week of pregnancy.

Endocrine gland

A gland that produces **hormones** (chemical messenger substances), which are released directly into the bloodstream rather than along tubes or ducts.

Endorphin

A morphine-like substance produced naturally by the body in times of pain and stress, and also activated during exercise.

Enzyme

A **protein** that accelerates chemical reactions within cells.

Epidermis

The outer layer of the skin; its box-shaped cells become flatter and scaler towards the surface.

Epiglottis

A leaflike flap of **cartilage** located at the entrance of the **larynx**, which covers the opening of the airways during swallowing and helps to prevent food or liquid from entering the windpipe (**trachea**).

Epithelium

Specialized covering or lining **tissue** that forms sheets and layers around and within many **organs** and other tissues.

Eustachian tube

Tube connecting the back of the nose to the **middle ear** cavity; allows air pressure to equalize on either side of the eardrum.

F**Fallopian tube**

One of the two tubes along which an **ovum** travels to the **uterus**, after release from an **ovary**; its fingerlike projections help to sweep the ovum into the tube.

Fertilization

The union of a sperm and an egg, after sexual intercourse or artificial insemination, or in a test tube.

Fetus

The developing baby from about the eighth week after **fertilization** until the time of birth. See **embryo**.

G**Gallbladder**

The fig-shaped bag lying under the **liver**, into which **bile** secreted by the liver passes to be stored.

Gastric juice

Liquid produced by the stomach lining that contains hydrochloric acid and digestive **enzymes**.

Gastrointestinal tract

The muscular tube that extends from the mouth, through the **pharynx**, **oesophagus**, stomach, and intestines, to the rectum. Also known as the digestive tract.